

NEW ZEALAND EDITION · MMXXVI

First Lambing Season

A practical field guide for Valais Blacknose ewes



Quick-start overview

Everything in this handbook expands on this section. If you read nothing else before the first ewe bags up, read these two pages.

HOW URGENCY IS SHOWN

GREEN — NORMAL · OBSERVE

AMBER — MONITOR · PREPARE

RED — CALL THE VET NOW

Colour is never the only carrier: every label also states the word, so the system survives grayscale printing and colour-blindness.

The final two weeks — normal

- Udder fills and firms (“bagging up”), from 1–4 weeks out. In Valais, part the belly wool to see it.
- Vulva lengthens, softens, pinkens.
- Tail-head ligaments slacken — rump looks sunken in the last 24–48 h.
- Ewe slows, lies more, keeps to herself; appetite may dip in the last days.

The final 24 hours — normal

- Separates from the flock; seeks a quiet corner.
- Restless: pawing/“nesting”, up and down, flank-watching, soft bleating.
- Clear or slightly cloudy mucus string from the vulva; may go off feed.

The three stages of labour

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	NORMAL DURATION	WHEN IT TURNS AMBER / RED
1 — cervix opens	Restless, paws, separates, mucus string; little or no straining	3–6 h (first-timers up to ~12 h)	AMBER: no progression after 6–8 h · RED: she turns dull or goes down
2 — lamb delivered	Water bag → feet → nose → lamb; strong rhythmic straining	Lamb within 30–60 min of the bag; ~30 min of feet showing	RED: 30 min hard straining, no progress · RED: 1 h after bag, no lamb

3 — placenta	Ewe licks lamb; afterbirth hangs, then drops	2–3 h (≤6 h fine)	AMBER → vet: not passed by 12–18 h · never pull
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30 min

hard straining without progress = ring the vet

2 h

latest the lamb should have its first suck

50 ml/kg

colostrum in the first feed (≈200 ml for a 4 kg lamb)

39–40 °C

normal newborn lamb temperature — below 39 °C, act

Warning signs that always matter

- **RED** 30 minutes of hard straining with nothing appearing — or no further progress.
- **RED** Head with no feet · one foot only · tail only · hooves soles-up with no nose.
- **RED** Any red/pink mass of tissue protruding (prolapse), before or after lambing.
- **RED** Fresh blood dripping, running or pooling.
- **RED** Ewe down, dull, “blind”, trembling or collapsed — before or after lambing.
- **RED** Lamb not breathing, or cold and floppy.
- **AMBER** Lamb not sucking by 2 hours.

WHEN TO CALL THE VET — THE ONE-LINE RULE

If you have watched for **30 minutes** and things are not clearly moving forward — or you see any **RED** sign — **ring the vet**. A too-early call costs a phone call. A late one can cost the ewe and the lamb.

Preparing before lambing

Preparation is the cheapest veterinary intervention there is. Everything here happens at least two weeks before the first due date.

Environment

- ☐ **Lambing paddock** — sheltered, well-drained, near the house, hazard-checked (troughs, gaps, dogs).
- ☐ **Shelter** — the NZ spring killer is **wind + rain + cold together**; shelter from the prevailing southerly beats warmth.
- ☐ **Pens** — at least one clean covered pen (~1.5 × 1.5 m); two is comfortable for three ewes.
- ☐ **Bedding** — deep dry straw or untreated shavings; replaced between ewes.
- ☐ **Lighting** — shed light working; head torch charged.
- ☐ **Water** — clean, fresh, at a height lambs cannot drown in.
- ☐ **Hygiene** — pens cleaned and disinfected pre-season; gloves and hand-washing between animals.
- ☐ **Isolation** — somewhere to separate a sick ewe or lamb.
- ☐ **Containment** — calm gates/hurdles. Valais are quiet and people-friendly: use that; never chase.
- ☐ **Mud** — rotate gateways and feed areas; mud drives navel infection and chilling.

The lambing kit

ITEM	WHY	WHEN USED	BEGINNER-SAFE?	CAUTION
Disposable gloves	Hygiene both ways	All handling	✓ Yes	Change between animals
Long obstetric gloves	For any internal exam	Trained hands only	▲ With instruction	Internal exams are not a beginner task
Obstetric lubricant	Prevents trauma	Any assistance	▲ With instruction	Use generously; never assist “dry”

Clean towels (many)	Dry, grip, warm	Every birth	✓ Yes	Wash between uses
Iodine navel spray/dip	Prevents navel / joint ill	Within 15 min of birth; repeat 2–4 h	✓ Yes	Cover cord and base fully
Digital thermometer	Objective triage	Any dull/cold animal	✓ Yes	Lamb normal 38.5–39.5 °C
Head torch + batteries	Night checks	Nightly	✓ Yes	—
Bucket + disinfectant	Clean water, clean hands	As needed	✓ Yes	Separate drinking bucket
Lambing ropes / snare	Hold a correctly-placed leg	Trained assistance only	✗ Not untrained	Never on a jaw; never for force
Bottle + lamb teat	Feeding backup	First 24 h+	✓ Yes	Only for a warm lamb that can swallow
Stomach tube + syringe	Feeding a weak lamb	Weak lambs	✗ Only if shown	A tube in the windpipe kills — get taught first
Colostrum (frozen / ewe-specific powder)	Life-saving first feed	First 24 h	✓ Yes	Thaw in warm water; never microwave/boil
Warming box / lamp / wheat bags	Reviving chilled lambs	Lamb < 39 °C	✓ Yes	Warm air ~35–40 °C; nothing hot touching the lamb
Small digital scales	Weight = earliest starvation alarm	Birth + daily if concerned	✓ Yes	Same time each day
Notebook / record card	Times matter	Every lambing	✓ Yes	Cards at back of this book
Clean lidded container	Colostrum storage	If milking the ewe	✓ Yes	Label and date

Stock marker spray	Match lambs to ewes	Multiples / moves	✓ Yes	—
Phone + power bank	You call from a paddock	Always	✓ Yes	Save day + after-hours vet numbers now

CLINICAL NOTE — GET TAUGHT BEFORE THE SEASON

Anything marked ▲ or ✕ should be demonstrated by your vet or an experienced sheep farmer **before** lambing. Many NZ clinics run pre-lambing smallholder evenings in winter — ask yours, and ask them to show you stomach-tubing on that visit.

Understanding late pregnancy

Your job in the last fortnight is pattern-recognition: learn each ewe's normal so the abnormal announces itself.

Udder (“bagging up”). Enlarges and firms from 1–4 weeks out; tight with filling teats in the last days, sometimes a wax plug on each teat. Valais belly wool hides it — part the wool or feel gently.

Vulva. Longer, softer, pinker, mildly swollen over the final 1–2 weeks; a mucus string in the final hours.

Pelvic ligaments. Either side of the tail head the ligaments soften — the sunken-rump look of the last 24–48 h.

Behaviour. Slower, lies more, separates; pawing, circling, up-and-down signal stage 1. A normally friendly Valais who stands apart is telling you something.

NORMAL VERSUS CONCERNING — LATE PREGNANCY

SIGN	NORMAL GREEN	WATCH AMBER	CALL THE VET RED
Udder	Gradual filling over weeks	Sudden hot, hard, painful; one side much larger	Hot painful udder + sick ewe (mastitis)
Vulva	Soft, pink, mild swelling; mucus near lambing	Small pink bulge when lying that retreats on standing	Any mass that stays out (bearing) · smelly or bloody discharge before labour
Appetite	Slight dip in final days	Off feed a full day	Off feed + dull / “blind” / staggy — sleepy sickness
Behaviour	Quieter, separates, nests	Restless hours without progressing	Down, trembling, teeth-grinding — sleepy sickness or milk fever
Movement	Slower, heavier	Limping — check feet (Valais can be footrot-prone on wet ground)	Unable to stand

TWO LATE-PREGNANCY EMERGENCIES — BOTH LOOK LIKE “THE EWE IS DOWN OR DOPEY BEFORE LAMBING”

Sleepy sickness (pregnancy toxemia / twin-lamb disease): off feed, dull, seems blind, head-pressing or star-gazing, staggy, then down. Energy shortfall in ewes carrying multiples. **RED — ring the vet; survival depends on early treatment.**

Milk fever (hypocalcaemia): sudden — often after yarding, weather or transport: wobbly, trembling, then flat, sometimes bloated. **RED — fatal in hours untreated, very treatable by a vet.** Never drench a flat ewe: she can inhale it.

Normal lambing, step by step

Most Valais ewes will do all of this alone at 2 a.m. and greet you smugly at dawn. Your skill is timing what you see — and staying out of the way.

Stage 1 — the cervix opens GREEN

She: separates, paws and nests, up and down, flank-watching, lip-curling, soft bleats; mild irregular straining late on. **You:** note the start time; watch from a distance every 30–60 min. Do not pen, chase or fuss — interference stalls early labour. **Duration:** 3–6 h (longer in first-timers). **Concern:** frantic behaviour beyond 6–8 h that never becomes straining, or dullness replacing restlessness.

Stage 2 — delivery GREEN, clock running

0 MIN Water bag appears	10–40 MIN Two hooves, then nose	30–60 MIN Lamb born	+5 MIN Head shake; up on chest; ewe licking
+15–30 MIN Stands	+30–60 MIN First suck	+10–45 MIN Next lamb, if twins	+2–3 H Placenta passed

Straining is strong and rhythmic; expect visible progress every 10–15 minutes once feet show. Timings are ranges, not deadlines — what matters is **progress**.

STOP — CALL THE VET

Hard straining for 30 minutes with no progress — nothing appearing, or the same two hooves not advancing — means the lamb may be stuck. Ring now; the vet drives while things are still saveable.

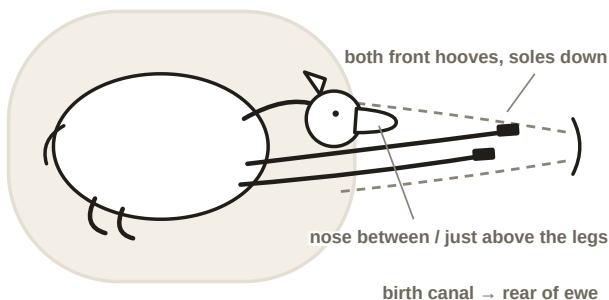
Stage 3 — the placenta GREEN

Red-purple membranes hang, then drop, usually by 2–3 h (≤ 6 h fine). The ewe may eat it — normal. **Never pull hanging membranes.** Not passed by

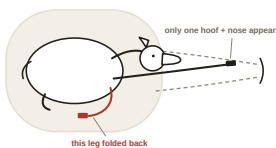
12–18 h, or the ewe is dull or the discharge smells → ring the vet (Section 6).

Normal and abnormal presentation

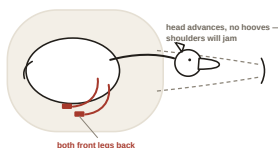
Presentation — which part of the lamb comes first and how legs and head are arranged. It decides whether a birth flows or jams. Learn one picture well: the diver. Everything else is “not the diver”.



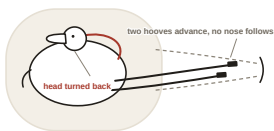
NORMAL — the diving position. Two front hooves, soles down, one usually slightly ahead; nose resting between or just above them. Head and shoulders follow. **Two toes + a nose = GREEN.** Anything else = at least AMBER.



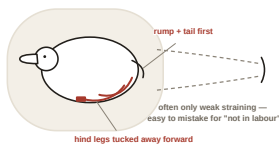
One front leg back. Externally: one hoof + nose. **RED** if not delivered within 30 min. Correction means repelling the head and fetching the leg — **trained hands, not yours.**



Both front legs back. Externally: head only, often a swelling tongue. Shoulders jam. **RED NOW.** Keep the head moist; never pull it. A swollen tongue does not mean a dead lamb.

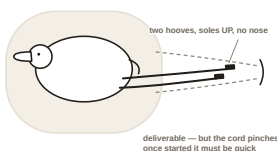


Head turned back. Externally: two soles-down hooves advance but no nose follows. **RED NOW** — one of the harder corrections; vet.

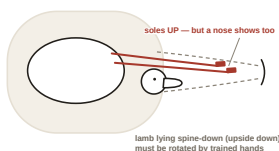


Breech. Externally: tail only, or a soft dome — and often only *weak* straining, so a “quiet” ewe making no progress can be a breech.

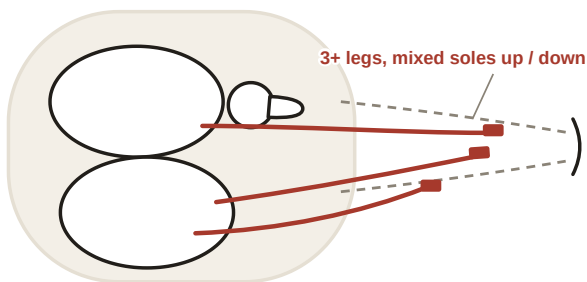
RED NOW.



Hind legs first. Externally: two hooves **soles up**, no nose. Deliverable — but the cord pinches once delivery starts, so it must be quick. **AMBER** → **RED** if not progressing in 15–20 min; assist only with experienced help present or the vet on the phone.



Upside down. Externally: soles up **and** a nose. The lamb must be rotated before delivery. **RED.**



two lambs entering the canal together
expert sorting required

Two lambs together. Externally: three or more legs, soles pointing different ways, possibly parts that don't add up. Sorting which leg belongs to which lamb is expert work. **RED NOW.**

THE HONEST RULE FOR A FIRST SEASON

You are not expected to correct a malpresentation. Your job is to **recognise “not the diver” early and get the right hands there fast** — the vet, or an experienced neighbour while the vet travels. That judgement made at 30 minutes, not 3 hours, is what saves lambs.

Common complications

Same format every time: what it is · what you may see · urgency · what you can safely do · what not to do · when to call. Safe first aid is labelled; everything else belongs to the vet or an experienced farmer.

Prolonged labour / failure to progress

RED AT 30 MIN

WHAT IT IS

Any stage that stalls: straining with nothing appearing, feet that stop advancing, or restlessness that never becomes labour.

SAFELY DO

Pen her calmly if easy; time everything; ring the vet and describe exactly what you can see; set out warm water, soap, towels, lube.

DO NOT

Repeatedly disturb her · go internal “to check” untrained · give any drug.

CALL THE VET IF

The 30-minute rule trips — don’t wait to be sure.

Dystocia — difficult or obstructed birth

RED

WHAT IT IS

The umbrella term for a lamb that cannot be delivered unaided: malpresentation, oversized lamb, ringwomb, two together.

SAFELY DO

Only if presentation is confirmed normal (two soles-down hooves + nose) and she is straining well but slow: clean gloved hands, plenty of lubricant, grip both legs above the fetlocks, pull **gently, only during her strains, downward in a curve toward her hocks**. One assisted strain with no movement → stop, ring.

DO NOT

Pull a head, a jaw or a single leg · pull between contractions · pull anything unidentified · use ropes or mechanical force.

CALL THE VET IF

Any resistance, any confusion about what you feel, or 5 minutes of gentle help achieves nothing.

Oversized lamb

RED

WHAT YOU MAY SEE

Normal presentation stuck at head/shoulders; a protruding head with a swelling tongue (classic with single lambs in well-fed ewes).

SAFELY DO

Keep the exposed head moist with a clean wet towel; keep membranes off the nose; ring the vet.

DO NOT

Apply traction to the head.

CALL THE VET

Immediately — some need a caesarean, and early calls mean both survive.

Ringwomb — incomplete cervical dilation

RED

WHAT YOU MAY SEE

Hours of stage-1 behaviour, perhaps membranes visible, but no feet and weak straining — the door never opens.

SAFELY DO

Nothing internal. Ring the vet — true ringwomb usually means caesarean.

DO NOT

Attempt to stretch anything.

CALL THE VET IF

Persistent stage 1 (6–8 h) with no stage 2.

Uterine inertia — contractions fade

RED

WHAT YOU MAY SEE

Labour that starts, then fades away; a dull ewe. Often rides with milk fever.

SAFELY DO

Ring the vet.

DO NOT

Wait “in case she starts again”.

Vaginal prolapse — “bearing” (before lambing)

RED ONCE IT STAYS OUT

WHAT IT IS

The vagina pushes out through the vulva under late-pregnancy pressure. NZ farmers call it a bearing.

WHAT YOU MAY SEE

A smooth pink/red rounded mass, orange-to-grapefruit sized — at first only when lying, later staying out.

SAFELY DO

Pen her quietly · keep the tissue clean and moist (clean lukewarm-wet towel held over it) · keep stock and flies off · follow your vet's prior instructions if they have shown you replacement and a retainer.

DO NOT

Push it back unwashed or unguided · replace a dry or dirty prolapse · leave her unwatched (a bearing can hide or complicate labour).

CALL THE VET IF

It stays out — always. Tell the vet she is due to lamb; plan her lambing together. Don't breed her again (bearings recur).

Uterine prolapse (after lambing)

RED — TOP EMERGENCY

WHAT IT IS

The whole uterus turns inside-out and comes out, usually within hours of lambing.

WHAT YOU MAY SEE

A **large** red/purple mass hanging as far as the hocks, covered in raised button-like bumps (cotyledons) — the buttons are how you know it is uterus, not a bearing.

SAFELY DO

Ring immediately and say “uterine prolapse” · keep her still and quiet, ideally lying · support and cover the mass with a clean towel soaked in clean lukewarm water · keep it off the ground · keep lambs near if she is calm.

DO NOT

Attempt replacement (the vet uses an epidural) · let her run or be chased · wash with anything stronger than clean water or saline.

Retained placenta

AMBER 12–18 H · RED IF SICK

WHAT YOU MAY SEE

Membranes still hanging 12–18+ hours after birth, or a smell developing (metritis — womb infection).

SAFELY DO

Trim dangling membranes below the hocks with clean scissors · keep her clean · check appetite and demeanour twice daily.

DO NOT

Pull — ever · tie weights to it.

CALL THE VET IF

Beyond 18 h, or any dullness, fever or foul smell.

Excessive bleeding

RED

WHAT YOU MAY SEE

Normal: blood-tinged fluid and light streaks. Abnormal: fresh blood **dripping, running or pooling**, large clots, a pale weak ewe.

SAFELY DO

Keep her still and quiet · note amount and rate for the vet (“cupful”, “steady drip”, “pooling”).

DO NOT

Go internal to find it · pack the vagina · give any drug.

CALL THE VET

Immediately.

Sleepy sickness — pregnancy toxemia

RED

WHAT YOU MAY SEE

Late pregnancy, usually multiples: off feed, dull, apparently blind, head-pressing, star-gazing, staggering, then down.

SAFELY DO

Ring the vet · if she can swallow and your vet advises it by phone, give an oral energy drench (propylene-glycol product from your kit) · feed, water, shelter.

DO NOT

Drench a flat ewe or one that can't swallow · assume she'll come right — untreated ewes die with their lambs.

Milk fever — hypocalcaemia

RED — HOURS MATTER

WHAT YOU MAY SEE

Sudden, often post-stress: wobbly, trembling, then flat on her side, sometimes bloated.

SAFELY DO

Prop her upright on her chest with a bale (stops bloat) · shade and shelter · ring the vet — response to calcium is dramatic and diagnostic.

DO NOT

Drench her · inject calcium untrained (dosing and placement need instruction; intravenous calcium is vet-only).

Mastitis

AMBER EARLY · RED IF SICK

WHAT YOU MAY SEE

One side hot, hard, swollen, painful; ewe walks stiffly behind, won't let lambs suck; milk watery, clotted or bloody. Worst form: udder skin cold and blue-black. **A suddenly-hungry lamb is often the first sign.**

SAFELY DO

Gently strip a squirt from each teat onto a dark surface daily in week one · bottle-feed the lambs if she won't.

DO NOT

Ignore it — it advances fast. Antibiotics and anti-inflammatories are veterinary decisions in NZ (restricted veterinary medicines).

CALL THE VET IF

Heat + pain + abnormal milk, discoloured skin, or any sick ewe.

Ewe down · collapse · suspected infection

RED

WHAT YOU MAY SEE

Down and can't rise; or fever signs — dull, fast breathing, off feed, temperature over 40 °C; or cold, pale and flat. Causes range from milk fever to metritis to internal bleeding — you don't need to diagnose.

SAFELY DO

Prop upright on her chest · shelter · water in reach · take her temperature if safe (normal 38.3–39.9 °C).

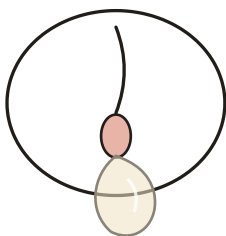
DO NOT

Lift by the wool · drench a flat ewe.

CALL THE VET

Immediately.

Terminology — four things that come out of a ewe

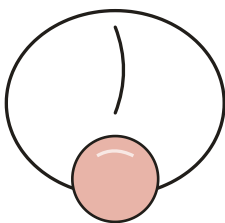


translucent, fluid inside

Water bag (fetal membranes) — translucent, fluid-filled, often bursts.

GREEN

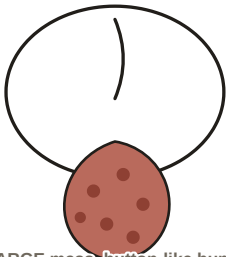
Start your stage-2 clock.



smooth pink ball, no bumps

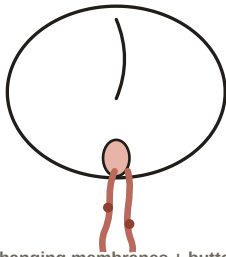
Vaginal prolapse — “bearing”

(usually *before* lambing) — smooth pink/red ball, orange → grapefruit size, no bumps. RED once it stays out.



LARGE mass, button-like bumps

Uterine prolapse (*after lambing*) — large ragged red/purple mass with button-like cotyledons, may hang to the hocks. **RED — EMERGENCY.**



hanging membranes + buttons

Placenta / afterbirth — loose red-purple membranes with buttons, hanging then dropping; often eaten. **GREEN** if within ~6 h. Never pull.

CLINICAL NOTE — REAL PHOTOGRAPHS

These schematics are drawn for recognition; before the season, look once at real photographs so nothing surprises you: NADIS *Lambing Part 3* — *vaginal and uterine prolapses* (nadis.org.uk) and Northland Vets' *Bearings* page (northvets.co.nz) carry clear clinical images. Some are graphic — that is what the real thing looks like.

Immediate newborn lamb care

Four windows: five minutes, thirty minutes, two hours, twenty-four hours. The ewe does most of the work — you verify.

First 5 minutes

1. **Breathing?** Watch the chest. Membranes over nose/mouth — **clear them at once** with fingers and a towel wipe.
2. **Not breathing?** Wipe nostrils → tickle deep in one nostril with a clean straw (triggers a gasp) → rub chest and ribs hard with a towel. A brief, supported, head-down hold by the hind legs lets fluid drain — seconds, never swinging. No breaths by ~1 minute: ring the vet while continuing.
3. **Let the ewe take over** — lamb at her nose; her licking dries, warms, bonds. Towel-dry only if she won't or the weather is foul.
4. **Navel:** soak/spray the whole cord and its base with iodine.
5. **Step back.** The first hour of licking and murmuring builds the bond everything else depends on.

First 30 minutes NORMAL

Head shake; up on the chest within minutes; standing attempts by 15–30 min; bleating answered by the ewe's low rumble.

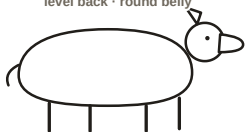
First 2 hours — the one thing that matters

The lamb must suck — confirm it, don't assume it. Normal: finds the udder, tail wiggles hard while sucking, then sleeps curled and full. Not fed by 2 h → Section 8. Safe and useful now: trim long wool hiding the teats (a genuine Valais issue) and strip each teat until the wax plug clears and milk squirts.

First 24 hours

- Repeat navel iodine at 2–4 h. Cord should dry and shrivel — wet, hot, swollen or smelly navel: AMBER ring the vet.
- Weigh and record. From tomorrow, ~250 g/day of gain is your lie-detector.
- Watch for meconium (first tar-black poo) and urine.

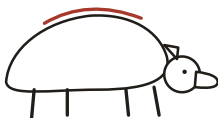
level back · round belly



Full lamb. Level back, round belly, stretches on rising, sleeps curled.

GREEN

arched back · head low · hollow flank



Hungry lamb. Arched back, head low, hollow “empty triangle” behind the ribs, constant bleating and butting. Hungry now = starving tonight — act same-day.

AMBER

Colostrum

The single biggest lever you have. Lambs are born with almost no immunity and small energy reserves; colostrum supplies antibodies, dense energy and a laxative — and the gut absorbs the antibodies best in the first six hours.

WHEN	TARGET	4 KG LAMB EXAMPLE
Within 2 h of birth (6 h at the outside)	50 ml per kg bodyweight	200 ml
First 24 h, split over 4+ feeds	~200 ml per kg	800 ml

WHERE SOURCES DIFFER

NZ industry guidance commonly says “at least 10% of bodyweight within 6–24 h”; UK/AHDB guidance says 200 ml/kg (20%) over 24 h. Practical read: **10% is the floor, ~20% the target, front-loaded early**. A lamb sucking a well-uddered ewe manages this by itself.

Has it actually fed?

Evidence, not hope: you saw sucking with tail-wiggling · belly feels full · lamb sleeps then stretches · teats look drawn. None of these by 2 h → milk the ewe and bottle-feed, or use backup.

Sources, best first

1. Its own mother — milked into a clean container if it won't suck.
2. Frozen colostrum from another of your ewes.
3. Ewe-specific commercial colostrum powder (NZ rural suppliers), mixed exactly per label.
4. *Emergency only*: cow colostrum — inferior; ask your vet before relying on it.

BEGINNER-SAFE

Thawing: stand frozen colostrum in warm (not hot) water; feed at body temperature. **Never microwave or boil** — heat destroys the antibodies. **Bottle-feed** any lamb that is warm and can suck.

DO NOT

Do not stomach-tube unless you have been shown how — a tube in the windpipe drowns the lamb. A lamb too weak to suck needs tubing: ring the vet or your experienced contact, and get taught for next time.

Hypothermia and weak lambs

Cold + wet + wind kills more NZ lambs than anything else. Starvation and chilling are one spiral: cold lambs don't suck, unfed lambs get cold. Break it with a thermometer, not a guess.

TEMPERATURE	STATUS	MEANING
39–40 °C	GREEN — NORMAL	Carry on
37–39 °C	AMBER — MILD HYPOTHERMIA	Act now: dry, shelter, feed, warm
Below 37 °C	RED — SEVERE	Follow the age rule below exactly

Cold lamb → dry it, out of the weather, take its temperature → then:

37–39 °C	<37 °C · UNDER ~5 H OLD
Feed + warm. Colostrum by suck or bottle (it must swallow), warm to ≥39 °C, back to mum, confirm sucking.	Warm first. Birth energy reserves remain: warm-air box ~35–40 °C, feed as soon as it can swallow.
<37 °C · OLDER THAN ~5 H	CAN'T LIFT HEAD / CAN'T SWALLOW
Do NOT warm first — ring the vet. Its glucose is spent; warming without energy kills. It needs intraperitoneal glucose (vet / trained person) <i>before</i> warming.	Nothing by mouth. Vet now. Feeding or tubing a lamb that can't swallow drowns it.

BEGINNER-SAFE WARMING

Covered box with towels and a heat lamp *above, never touching*; or wrapped warm (not hot) wheat bags/water bottles; or inside your jacket against your skin while you organise. Check every 20–30 minutes. Target: back over 39 °C, vigorous, then fed, then re-mothered in a pen with sucking confirmed.

DO NOT

No hot-water immersion unattended · no direct contact with heaters or hot bottles · no hair dryer on hot held close · never “warm and hope” for a flat lamb over five hours old.

Ewe care after lambing

A healthy post-lambing ewe is busy: licking, murmuring, eating, drinking. Your checks take two minutes a day — and the first week is when the quiet problems surface.

NORMAL

Up and licking within minutes · eats and drinks keenly (offer lukewarm water — she may take litres) · rumbling nicker · stands for sucking · placenta by ~6 h · discharge (**lochia**) red-brown, reducing over 2–3 weeks, **never foul-smelling**.

DAILY CHECKS — FIRST WEEK

- ☐ Eating, drinking, chewing cud
- ☐ Udder soft after feeding, both sides even, both teats giving milk (strip each on day 1)
- ☐ Discharge reducing, no smell
- ☐ Placenta accounted for (she may have eaten it)
- ☐ Moving freely, no straining
- ☐ Mothering: keeps the lamb close, answers its bleat

RED

Off feed or dull (temp > 40 °C) · foul or pus-like discharge (metritis) · fresh bleeding · straining after all lambs born (another lamb? prolapse?) · down and can't rise.

AMBER

Hot painful udder (mastitis — vet if any heat + pain + abnormal milk) · rejecting the lamb: pen them close, restrain gently for supervised sucks, and ring your vet or experienced contact if it isn't resolving within hours.

MOVE OR LEAVE?

Leave the family on the birth site a few hours if weather allows — early moves are a top cause of mismothering. If weather turns, move calmly: carry the lamb low, in her sight, walking slowly backward in front of her; then pen ewe + lambs together 24–48 h, especially twins or a first-time mum.

Twins and multiple births

Your scan result is the plan: record it on each ewe card and trust it. The interval between lambs is usually short — the danger is renewed straining that produces nothing.

- **Another coming?** After a lamb she rests, then gets restless and strains again. Typical interval 10–45 min — or she delivers the next while licking the first.
- **Done?** Settles into steady licking and feeding, stops straining, flanks slacken.
- **RED** Renewed **hard straining > 30 min** with no lamb · scan said two and one arrived over an hour ago with her now unsettled or unwell.
- **Colostrum for every lamb.** The strong twin will cheerfully take both shares — confirm each one sucking; weigh both; the lighter one gets priority checks.
- **Mismothering.** Ewes can walk off with lamb one while lamb two arrives, or favour one twin. Pen the family 24–48 h; matching marker numbers on ewe and lambs before any move.
- Triplets in a Valais would be unusual — three mouths generally need supervised feeding or a bottle top-up; ask your vet.

The first 72 hours

Twice-daily lamb checks, daily ewe checks. Weight and demeanour tell you the truth before anything else does.

LAMB — TWICE DAILY

- ☐ Sucking observed (tail-wiggle); belly full
- ☐ Warm mouth, bright eye, stretches on rising
- ☐ Straight back — not hunched or tucked-up
- ☐ Breathing quiet — no rattle, grunt or panting
- ☐ Peeing; meconium passed day 1, then yellow milk-poo (clean off any gluing the tail)
- ☐ Navel dry, shrivelling — not wet, hot, swollen or smelly
- ☐ Weight: gaining ~250 g+/day
- ☐ No swollen joints, no reluctance to stand — joint/navel ill is a **RED**
- ☐ No “watery mouth”: drooly, cold-mouthed, bloated, tucked-up lamb days 1–3 is a **RED**

ewe — DAILY

- ☐ Appetite and water intake strong
- ☐ Udder even, soft after sucking, no heat or pain
- ☐ Temperature only if she seems off — normal 38.3–39.9 °C
- ☐ Discharge reducing, never smelly
- ☐ Placenta accounted for
- ☐ Sound on her feet
- ☐ Mothering solidly — answers the lamb, stands to feed

Valais Blacknose — breed notes

Little peer-reviewed lambing data exists for this breed; what follows separates the reasonably established from breeder anecdote — and says which is which.

Reasonably established

- **Provenance and value.** The NZ flock descends from UK embryos; first NZ lambs born 2017; the NZ Valais Blacknose Sheep Society (under the NZ Sheepbreeders Association) holds the breed standard. Animals are few and valuable — so **set a low threshold for calling the vet**: the economics that make commercial farmers wait do not apply to your ewes, and shouldn't.
- **Fleece grows ~30 cm/year; shorn twice yearly.** Consequences: **crutch/dag the rear and trim around the udder before lambing** (vulva visibility, hygiene, teat access); watch face wool ("wool blindness"); a sodden fleece is heavy and chilling — shelter matters even more than for other breeds.
- **Both sexes horned.** Lamb horn buds are no obstacle at birth. Handle ewes by chest and shoulders, never by horns, near lambing.
- **Alpine feet on soft wet NZ ground.** Breeders consistently report proactive foot care is needed (scald/footrot risk). A lame ewe lambs and mothers badly — check feet pre-lambing. (*Breeder observation, consistent with NZ experience of imported wool breeds.*)

Breeder-reported — treat as anecdote

- Widely described as **relatively easy lambers** with moderate birth weights, **strong maternal instincts** and good milk; can cycle outside the usual season. Occasional reports of head/shoulder-related difficulty exist in some lines. **Run this season on the standard timings in this book, not on breed reputation.**
- Their tameness is real and useful: most Valais ewes tolerate udder and lamb checks without a yarding drama. Build the habit with quiet daily handling before lambing.

YOUR OWN EVIDENCE

The record cards at the back are how you build breed-specific knowledge that actually applies to *your* three ewes. Fill them in every time — next season's handbook is written in them.

New Zealand seasonal & practical notes

The weather is the predator here. Everything else is logistics you can arrange in advance.

- **Storm doctrine.** Lamb losses spike in southerly fronts — cold + wet + wind. Watch the forecast against due dates; move ewes to the sheltered paddock or shed **before** the front, not during it.
- **Outdoors vs pens.** Healthy ewes lamb well outdoors on clean sheltered ground. Pens are for bonding, foul weather, assisted births and concerns — cleaned between families (warm wet bedding grows the bugs behind navel ill and watery mouth).
- **Vet access.** Rural after-hours help can be 30–60+ minutes away. That travel time is *why* the 30-minute rule exists — ring at the point of doubt so the vet drives while things are saveable. Ask your clinic now: after-hours number, expected travel time, what to have ready, and whether they run pre-lambing training.
- **Products.** Iodine sprays, obstetric lube, feeders and tubes, colostrum powders, lamb covers, thermometers: all at NZ rural suppliers (Farmlands, PGG Wrightson, Shoof, vet clinics) — buy before August. Antibiotics, calcium injections and most treatments are **restricted veterinary medicines** — they come via your vet, another reason to be registered with a clinic before lambing.
- **Legal baseline.** The MPI Code of Welfare (Sheep and Beef Cattle) requires timely assistance with birthing difficulty — waiting past the thresholds in this book isn't just risky, it falls short of the code.
- **People-safety.** Birth fluids carry zoonoses (campylobacter, toxoplasma and others): gloves always, wash up after, and **pregnant women should avoid contact with lambing ewes entirely**. Compost or bury placentas beyond the reach of dogs.

Emergency cheat sheet

WHAT YOU SEE	LIKELY MEANING	DO	URGENCY
Straining 30 min, nothing appearing	Lamb stuck / not entering canal	Ring vet now; pen her, keep calm	RED
Water bag 1 h ago, no lamb	Stalled stage 2	Ring vet now	RED
One foot + nose only	Front leg back	Ring vet; do not pull	RED
Head out, no feet	Both legs back — will jam	Ring vet; keep head moist; never pull the head	RED
Feet out, no nose follows	Head turned back	Ring vet; do not pull	RED
Tail only / soft dome	Breech — may strain only weakly	Ring vet even if she seems calm	RED
Two hooves soles-up, no nose	Hind legs first — must be quick	Ring vet; assist only with experienced help / phone guidance	AMBER – RED
Hard straining between lambs >30 min	Next lamb stuck	Ring vet	RED
Lamb born, not breathing	Airway blocked / stunned	Clear nose NOW · straw-tickle nostril · rub hard · brief head-down drain · ring vet at 1 min	RED
Lamb cold / weak / floppy	Hypothermia ± starvation	Thermometer. 37–39 °C: dry, feed, warm. <37 °C + over ~5 h old: do NOT warm first — vet (glucose)	RED

Lamb won't suck by 2 h	Starvation clock running	Milk ewe + bottle if it can swallow; can't swallow → vet (tubing is trained-only)	AMBER → RED
Smooth pink ball at vulva (pre-lambing)	Bearing (vaginal prolapse)	Clean wet towel over it; pen her; ring vet	RED
Large bumpy red mass (post-lambing)	Uterine prolapse	Keep her still; cover with clean wet towel; ring vet NOW	RED
Fresh blood dripping / pooling	Haemorrhage	Keep her still; ring vet now	RED
Membranes hanging > 18 h	Retained placenta	Ring vet; never pull	AMBER (RED if sick)
Ewe down / dopey / "blind"	Sleepy sickness · milk fever · other	Prop on chest, shelter, ring vet NOW; never drench if flat	RED

THE ONE RULE

Thirty minutes of trying without progress — yours or hers — means **ring the vet.**

Emergency contacts & ewe records

Fill these in before lambing — in pen, on the printed copy that lives with the kit.

Emergency contacts

Primary veterinarian:

After-hours veterinarian:

Backup veterinary clinic:

Experienced sheep/lambing contact:

Property address / directions for the vet:

Nearest sheltered lambing area:

Phone: _____

Phone: _____

Phone: _____

Phone: _____

Ewe 1

Name / tag: _____

Breed: Valais Blacknose

Expected lambing date: _____

Scanning result: _____

Expected number of lambs: _____

Previous lambing history: _____

Labour started: _____

Lamb 1 born: _____

Lamb 2 born: _____

Lamb 3 born: _____

Placenta passed: _____

Vet contacted: _____

Treatments: _____

Outcome: _____

Notes: _____

Ewe 2

Name / tag: _____

Breed: Valais Blacknose

Expected lambing date: _____

Scanning result: _____

Expected number of lambs: _____

Previous lambing history: _____

Labour started: _____

Lamb 1 born: _____

Lamb 2 born: _____

Lamb 3 born: _____

Placenta passed: _____

Vet contacted: _____

Treatments: _____

Outcome: _____

Notes: _____

Ewe 3

Name / tag: _____

Breed: Valais Blacknose

Expected lambing date: _____

Scanning result: _____

Expected number of lambs: _____

Previous lambing history: _____

Labour started: _____

Lamb 1 born: _____

Lamb 2 born: _____

Lamb 3 born: _____

Placenta passed: _____

Vet contacted: _____

Treatments: _____

Outcome: _____

Notes: _____

Sources & further reading

Clinically important numbers in this handbook trace to the sources below. Where reputable sources disagree (colostrum totals), both figures appear in the text with a practical recommendation.

NEW ZEALAND

1. Beef + Lamb New Zealand — *Lamb survival resources*.
beeflambnz.com/knowledge-hub/lamb-survival-resources
2. Beef + Lamb New Zealand — *Focusing on lamb survival*.
beeflambnz.com/news/focusing-lamb-survival
3. NZVA — *Lamb survival: coping with adverse spring weather*. nzva.org.nz
4. Northland Veterinary Group — *Bearings / vaginal prolapses in sheep*.
northvets.co.nz
5. Franklin Vets — *A guide to pregnancy toxæmia in ewes*. franklinvets.co.nz
6. Anexa Veterinary Services — *Sleepy sickness*. anexa.co.nz · Rangiora Vet Centre — *Sleepy sickness in pregnant ewes*. rangioravetcentre.co.nz
7. MPI — *Codes of welfare (Sheep and Beef Cattle)*. mpi.govt.nz/animals/animal-welfare/codes

INTERNATIONAL VETERINARY REFERENCES

8. NADIS (UK) — *Lambing Part 1: The Basics* (stages, timings). nadis.org.uk
9. NADIS (UK) — *Lambing Part 3: Vaginal and uterine prolapses*. nadis.org.uk
10. AHDB (UK) — *Colostrum management for lambs* (50 ml/kg by 2–6 h; 200 ml/kg per 24 h). ahdb.org.uk
11. Farm Advisory Service Scotland — *Treating hypothermia in newborn lambs* (bands; 5-hour rule). fas.scot · SRUC — *Decision tree for suspected hypothermia and hypoglycaemia*. epidemiology.sruc.ac.uk
12. Merck/MSD Veterinary Manual — *Retained fetal membranes in does and ewes; Vaginal and cervical prolapse in cattle and sheep*. merckvetmanual.com
13. Ohio State University Sheep Team — *Managing starvation/hypothermia; Prolapses in sheep*. u.osu.edu/sheep

BREED

14. NZ Sheepbreeders Association — *Valais Blacknose · Valais Blacknose in NZ*.
nzsheep.co.nz/valais-blacknose
15. Rare Breeds Conservation Society of NZ — *Valais Blacknose sheep*.
rarebreeds.co.nz/valais.html
16. Valais Blacknose New Zealand (breeder society). valaisblacknose.co.nz

Compiled August 2026. Breed-specific lambing claims for Valais Blacknose are breeder-reported unless otherwise stated; no peer-reviewed lambing dataset for the breed was identified at the time of writing. This handbook is general guidance for first-time owners in New Zealand and does not replace veterinary advice for an individual animal.